Chavan, in fact, was made to resign even before an FIR could be filed in the case. When I met him just before he resigned, he had a forlorn look. ‘I am not being given a chance to defend myself. The Adarsh flats were never meant for Kargil widows,’ was his grouse. The truth is, even if he could make out a case, no one was ready to believe him. He was stuck with the label of a chief minister who had builders with questionable reputations hanging around his office all the time.

Frenzied headlines accompanied each scam, pushing the government even further on the defensive. ‘We had become hyper-sensitive to public opinion and what was playing out in the media, especially prime-time television. Some of it was deliberately sensationalized, but we just didn’t know how to counter it,’ confessed a senior minister. In the public perception, the Centre was an inept, corrupt ancien régime, almost as unpopular as the British raj. The Anna movement latched on to this growing public outrage with great dexterity. TV images of swelling crowds only accentuated a crisis of confidence from which the UPA would never quite recover.

Significantly, Sonia Gandhi wasn’t in the country when the Anna Hazare movement captured the national imagination in August 2011. The leadership vacuum created by her absence was never felt more strongly. Rahul Gandhi, meant to be the de facto leader of the Congress in her absence, was mostly absent as well. At a time when he was needed the most, to rally his forces, seize the political initiative, perhaps even defuse the Anna bomb by reaching out to the elderly campaigner, Rahul abdicated from his responsibilities.

And the prime minister, who should have taken charge, remained largely silent. Dr Singh had never been a great communicator. But in a crisis hour, the prolonged, almost stupefied silence of the man who was officially the chief executive of the Indian state was a recipe for disaster. ‘Dr Singh had outsourced the entire Anna issue to the Congress party and key ministers—he just didn’t want to get involved,’ is how one minister put it to me later. It was almost as if the bureaucrat in Dr Singh had consumed his political being. Anna was a ticking-bomb file that he just didn’t want to touch for